一颗刺果钩出的发明

The Burrs That Became Velcro



衣服上的刺果，怎样变成了日常搭扣？

英文原文

In 1941 George de Mestral, a **Swiss** engineer, returned from hunting in the Alps with his **hound**, an Irish Pointer. **Prickly** burdock **seed-heads** had **hitched** themselves to his clothes and lay **tangled** in the dog's **fur**. Under a microscope he saw thousands of tiny **barbs**, each a **hook grasping** the small **loops** in cloth.

Few **took** his idea **seriously** at first. In Lyon, then a **weaving** centre, a cotton version proved too **frail** to survive **abrasion**. Working with a **textiles** firm, he turned to **nylon**, whose hooks were **stiff** enough to hold yet easy to **pull apart**. The **trial-and-error** at the **looms** and **mills** lasted about ten years.

The name Velcro **merged** two French words, velours, meaning **velvet**, and crochet, meaning hook. A US patent **duly** followed in 1955. In 1959 a New York fashion show sent **apparel stitched** with the **fasteners** down the **runway**. The public was less **charmed** than expected, **mostly** because of the **aesthetic**.

The **underdog** proved its **utility** in **outer space**. NASA used it in the **Apollo programme** to keep **gear anchored in weightlessness**, so that nothing would **hover** in **mid-air**. Apollo 11 was **equipped with** a **sizeable** amount, about 3,300 square inches. NASA did not invent the nylon **clasp**.

When the patent **ran out** in 1978, **cut-price knock-offs** from other countries **overran** the market, and a **niche** product went **mainstream**. In 2017, to stop its **brand-name melting into** a **generic noun**, the company asked people to call such **mimics** hook and loop fasteners. **In effect**, the firm was asking the public to stop using its own name for **rivals'** goods.

中文译文

1941年，乔治·德·梅斯特拉尔，一位瑞士的工程师，带着他的猎犬，一只爱尔兰的指示犬，从阿尔卑斯山的打猎中归来。多刺的牛蒡种子头已把它们自己钩在了他的衣服上，并缠绕在狗的毛皮里。在显微镜下，他看到成千上万个细小的倒刺，每一个（如同）一个钩子，抓住布料上的小圈。

起初，很少有人认真看待他的想法。在里昂，当时的一个纺织中心，一个棉制版本被证明太脆弱，以至于无法在磨损中存活下来。与一家纺织品公司合作，他转向了尼龙，其钩子足够坚硬且不易弯曲，既能扣住，又容易拉开。在织机旁和工厂里的反复试验持续了约十年。

Velcro 这个名字合并了两个法语词，velours 意为天鹅绒，crochet 意为钩子。1955年，一项美国专利如期而至。1959年，纽约一场时装秀让缝有这种搭扣的服装走上T台。公众却不如预期那样着迷，主要是因为它的审美。

这个不被看好的（发明）在外太空证明了自己的用处。美国航天局在阿波罗计划中使用了它，以便在失重状态下保持装备固定，从而没有任何东西会在半空中飘浮。阿波罗11号配备了相当多的用量，约3,300平方英寸。美国航天局并没有发明这种尼龙扣件。

1978年专利到期后，来自其他国家的廉价的仿制品/山寨品泛滥于市场，一种小众产品成了主流。2017年，为了阻止其品牌名逐渐消融为一个通用的名词，该公司要求人们把这类仿品称作为“钩毛搭扣”。实际上，这家公司是在请求公众停止将其自己的名字用在对手的商品上。

词汇与表达

Swiss adj.
瑞士的

hound n.
猎犬

Prickly adj.
多刺的

seed-heads n.
种子头

hitched v.
钩在了

tangled adj.
缠绕

fur n.
毛皮

barbs n.
倒刺
thousands of tiny barbs

hook n.
钩子

grasping v.
抓住
a hook grasping the small loops

loops n.
圈
the small loops in cloth

took seriously 表达
认真看待

weaving n.
纺织

frail adj.
脆弱
a cotton version proved too frail

abrasion n.
磨损
to survive abrasion

textiles n.
纺织品

nylon n.
尼龙
he turned to nylon

stiff adj.
坚硬且不易弯曲
hooks were stiff enough to hold

pull apart 动词短语
拉开
easy to pull apart

trial-and-error n.
反复试验
The trial-and-error

looms n.
织机

mills n.
工厂

merged v.
合并了
merged two French words

velvet n.
天鹅绒

duly adv.
如期

apparel n.
服装
apparel stitched with the fasteners

stitched v.
缝有

fasteners n.
搭扣
apparel stitched with the fasteners

词汇与表达（续）

runway n.
T台

charmed v.
着迷

mostly adv.
主要

aesthetic n.
审美
mostly because of the aesthetic

underdog n.
不被看好的（发明）

utility n.
用处
proved its utility in outer space

outer space n.
外太空

in weightlessness n.
失重状态下

Apollo programme n.
阿波罗计划

gear n.
装备

anchored v.
固定
keep gear anchored in weightlessness

hover v.
飘浮
hover in mid-air

mid-air n.
半空

equipped with v.
配备了
was equipped with a sizeable amount

sizeable adj.
相当多的

clasp n.
扣件

ran out v.
到期
the patent ran out in 1978

cut-price adj.
廉价的

knock-offs n.
仿制品/山寨品

overran v.
泛滥于

niche n.
小众
a niche product went mainstream

mainstream n.
主流
a niche product went mainstream

brand-name n.
品牌名

melting into v.
消融为

generic adj.
通用的
a generic noun

noun n.
名词

mimics n.
仿品

In effect 副词短语
实际上
In effect, the firm

rivals' n.
对手的

文章简述

- 启发：瑞士工程师梅斯特拉尔发现，衣服和狗毛上的刺果靠小钩挂住毛圈，便仿照它设计出能反复扣合、拉开的搭扣，也就是常说的魔术贴。
- 试制：棉制搭扣很快磨坏，他改用尼龙，反复试验约十年，1955年获得美国专利。
- 应用：公众反应不如预期热烈，主要是它的样式不合审美；美国航天局后来在阿波罗计划中用它固定失重中的装备，但不是它的发明者。
- 普及：1978年专利到期后，廉价仿品涌入市场，原本小众的搭扣逐渐成为日常用品。
- 正名：Velcro是品牌名。2017年品牌方请公众把仿品叫作钩毛搭扣，避免大家拿自家品牌去称呼所有同类产品。